My Name is Rachel Corrie

Edited by Alan Rickman and Katharine Viner

(Taken from the Writings of Rachel Corrie)

RACHEL: (Pg 18) We are all born and someday we'll all die. Most likely to some degree alone. What if our aloneness isn't a tragedy? What if our aloneness is what allows us to speak the truth without being afraid? What if our aloneness is what allows us to experience the world as a dynamic presence – as a changeable, interactive thing? If I lived in Bosnia or Rwanda, needless death wouldn't be a distant symbol to me, it wouldn't be a metaphor, it would be a reality. I have no right to this metaphor. But I use it to console myself. To give a fraction of meaning to something enormous and needless.

INTRODUCTION

In 2003, American Rachel Corrie arrived in Gaza with a small contingent of international peace activists committed to protect the homes of Palestinian families from demolition. Corrie believed that her western features and blonde hair would deter the bulldozer, but she was wrong.

Today, nearly 20 years later, the violence in Gaza continues. It is often presented as a conflict between two equal sides with irreconcilable claims to one piece of land. In reality, this is a conflict between Israel, with one of the world's most powerful and well-funded militaries and an indigenous population of Palestinians that has been occupied, displaced and exiled for decades.

This is the first-hand account of events occurring during 2003 culled from Rachel Corrie's diary and edited by Alan Rickman and Katharine Viner . . . My Name is Rachel Corrie

January 25, 2003 (Arriving for training)

RACHEL: Very little problem at the airport. The woman behind the glass appeared not to notice my shaking hands. **(Pg 19)** The training . . . there was noise and flashing lights outside – but it wasn't real for me somehow because I was inside this building with these people. Everyone extending theories into the air.

Notes from Training: When talking – no hearsay. Don't appear to judge rightness or wrongness. Non-Violence – Don't touch those we're confronting. Don't run. Carry

nothing that could be used as a weapon. **(Pg 24)** We've been wavering between five and six of us internationals. Clearly, we are too few.

February 7th – Rafah

(Pg 23) I have been in Palestine for two weeks now, and I have very few words to describe what I see. You just can't imagine it unless you see it. And even then your experience is not at **all** the reality: **(Pg 20)** The West Bank and Gaza are under extremely strict curfew. You are not allowed to leave your house at all. Not for food. Nothing. The reality of curfew, of the checkpoints. People live like this . . . [at least] **(Pg 23-24)** I have money to buy water. I have the option of leaving.

I don't know if many of the children here have ever existed without tank-shell holes in their walls. Can you forgive the world for years spent existing – just existing?

Rafah is a city of 140,000 people, 60 percent of whom are refugees. The Israeli army is building a wall between Rafah and the border. 602 homes have been completely bulldozed. Nowhere is invulnerable to Apache helicopters or the cameras of invisible drones we hear buzzing over the city for hours at a time.

(Pg 25) There are no rules. There is no fairness. There are no guarantees. It's all just a shrug. And with that enormous shrug between being and not being. And I knew, the shrug would happen at the end of my life – I knew. My whole life is going to amount to one shrug and a shake of the head, so it if comes in eighty years or at 8 PM -- Who cares? Me. That's my job.

(Pg 27) *(Writing)* Mom, I spent the evening and this morning with a family on the front line. The two front rooms of their house are unusable because gunshots have been fired through the walls, so the whole family sleeps in the parents' bedroom. I sleep on the floor next to the youngest daughter. I am amazed at their strength in defending their humanity against the constant presence of death. I think the word is dignity.

March 9: **(Pg 35-36)** Ten greenhouses destroyed. [but] 300 people are dependent on

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those farms to live. 200 men arrested - Six in hospital. They don't understand what has happened.

March 13: Intensive care unit – 12-year-old girl shot from tower in school near Nasser hospital. Shots inside hospital – three injured – nurses. Houses demolished – 41 injured.

Yesterday I watched a father lead his two tiny children out into the sight of tanks and a sniper tower and bulldozers because he thought his house was going to be exploded. This man felt it was less of a risk to walk out in view of the tanks with his kids than to stay in his house. I was scared they were all going to be shot, and I tried to stand between them and the tank.

Mom, I thought a lot about what you said about Palestinian violence not helping the situation. 60,000 people from Rafah worked in Israel two years ago. Now only 600 can go there for jobs.

The airport? No. Runways demolished, totally closed. The border for trade with Egypt has a sniper tower in the middle of the crossing. Access to the ocean – completely cut off in the last two years.

(Pg 37) So when someone says that any act of Palestinian violence justifies Israel's actions, not only do I question that logic in light of the Geneva Convention, I question that logic on the basis of common sense.

If any of us lived with children in a place where soldiers and tanks and bulldozers could come for us at any moment. If we had no means of economic survival and our houses were demolished, don't you think most people would defend themselves as best they could?

(Pg 38) I'm having a hard time right now. I feel sick to my stomach from being doted on by people who are facing doom. I know that from the United States it all sounds like hyperbole. The kindness of the people here, coupled with the willful destruction of their lives, makes it seem unreal to me. I can't believe that something like this can happen in the world without a bigger outcry. It hurts me to witness how awful we can allow the

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world to be.

This has to stop. I still really want to dance around to Pat Benetar and have boyfriends. But I also want this to stop. Disbelief. Horror. Disappointment. I am disappointed that this is the base reality of our world and that we, in fact, participate in it. This is not what I asked for when I came into this world. This is not at all what the people here asked for. **(Pg 39)** Sorry for the diatribe . . . . I love you and Dad. *(She leaves)*

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(from the transcript of an eyewitness account by Tom Dale – A reporter's voice)

REPORTER: Rachel walked to place herself in between the home and the bulldozer. It continued toward her with a mound of earth building up in front of it. And as the mound of earth reached Rachel, she had to climb to prevent being overwhelmed by it. This put her head and shoulders above the top of the bulldozer blade, clearly in the view of the driver, so he knew **absolutely** that she was there.

CONCLUSION

Rachel Corrie was crushed to death by an Israeli bulldozer on March 16, 2003. An Israeli district court judge ruled her death an accident for which the state of Israel was not responsible.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Edited by Alan Rickman and Katharine Viner
ISBN: 978-0822222224
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service
Date (Month/Year): April 2008

AWARD HISTORY

2019 National Qualifier – MS
IL State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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